

Canon i560

Blazing cannon

The Canon i560 broke all the speed records that were established thus far. The text printout shot out in an astonishing 11 seconds—the best registered till date had been 14 seconds. The test photo, too, zoomed out in a quick 141 seconds.

With such speeds we expected print quality to diminish, but surprisingly, the Canon i560 set the benchmarks for the other printers. Not even the upmarket Canon i905D could match its quality. The only printer that came close was the HP 5160. However, when it comes to photograph printing, it still seems to be HP's playground—they beat all the printers on this turf, and the Canon i560 was no exception.

The printer is beautifully designed to hide away its expanses. It is bound to appeal to those worrying about an impeccable décor.

Its well-crafted dimensions ensure that it doesn't take up too much desk space. The areas near the extendable paper trays are well protected by plastic panels that act as dust caps. The Pictbridge port is in the front. There are no controls to set the preferences for the Pictbridge function; these can be set via the controls on the digital camera.

The Canon i560 comes with four ink tanks, and hence, is more cost effective in the long run, since you can replace only the cartridge that runs out first. On the cost-per-page analysis, a black ink printout will cost you around Rs 2 whereas a colour printout will lighten your pocket by Rs 2.50. Installation of the printer was a no-sweat affair. Drivers loaded perfectly, and allowed complete control over the printer's settings and preferences.

Priced at Rs 9,995, the Canon i560 is definitely worth the money. If you need an exceptionally fast printer and your work pertains to text and combo-documents, buy the i560—it will deliver.

- + Class-leading print speeds
- None



Canon i560		B
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Build quality	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Value for money	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	

Epson Stylus Photo 830

Six colours, zero appeal



Speed-wise, the Epson Stylus Photo 830 is stuck in the middle—the Canon printers are too fast for the Epson 830 to catch up with and the HPs were too slow to give it competition. However, it got beaten black and blue when printing photographs—it took around 10 minutes to complete the job; in contrast, the Canon i560 took 2 minutes to do so.

Despite its claims of a 5,760 dpi resolution, we found it lacking in the

photo-printing department by a huge margin. The printed text was smudged and jagged along the edges and way behind the standards set by the Canon i455 and i560. The photograph was very detailed with every small area highlighted. The photo colours had too much of contrast, making them look surreal rather than natural.

The Epson 830 is quite bulky, and requires sizeable desk space. The design is classic Epson. The paper-feeding mechanism is top-loading and has to be guarded against dust. The input tray holds 100 A4 sheets. The three control buttons are placed on the top for easy access. The two-cartridge system uses a black cartridge and one comprising 5 colours. The integrated colour cartridge is a bad idea since running out of one colour will mean replacing the entire module.

It has a photo cartridge, wherein you have six colours as opposed to the four in a regular inkjet printer. This feature should have brought better colour reproduction capability, but it didn't. Our black page printout cost us Rs 3 and the colour Rs 2.

- Slow
- Lacks quality output

Epson Stylus Photo 830		C
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Build quality	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Value for money	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	

Jargon buster

Bleed: The outer region of the page that falls outside the printing range of the printer.

Buffer: This is the memory within the printer that stores data from the PC until it's printed. Currently, this varies from 16 KB to 16 MB. The greater the buffer, the better is the handling of large print jobs.

CMYK: This is an acronym for the four-colour process printing industry standard for cyan, magenta, yellow and black. By combining these four colours, a printer can print all possible colours. Some newer printers use a six-cartridge concept—with a lighter version of cyan and magenta each.

Colour Balance: This term refers to the correct combination of cyan, magenta and yellow required to reproduce the colours of the original scene or object.

DPI: Dots per inch is a measure of the number of dots printed per square inch. For example, a 300 dpi printer produces 90,000 dots in a square inch. Higher dpi values produce sharper printouts—the minimum dpi supported by any printer today is 600.

Duplexing: This process helps you print on both sides of a page, thus reducing wastage of paper. These days, many printers come with this utility.

International paper sizes: The International Standards Organisation (ISO) categorises paper into three sizes: A, B and C. Series A is used for general printing, Series B for posters and charts, while Series C stands for envelopes and stationery. A detailed report on paper sizes is available at <http://www.ci.cam.ac.uk/~mgk25/iso-paper.html>

PostScript: This is a page-description language. It instructs the printer about where to place ink. PostScript was invented by Adobe. Currently in version 3, it supports complex page layouts and provides excellent quality. PostScript has become the *de facto* standard in imaging technology.